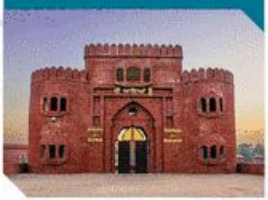
CHASING GREY GHOSTS



Snow leopards are called 'grey ghosts' for a reason. Not many get to see them. Writer Peter Matthiessen, for instance, spent two months looking for one in Nepal but found nothing. In his 1978 classic, *The Snow Leopard*, he consoles himself by saying, "I am not disappointed...that its frosty eyes watch us from the mountain—that is enough." Since not all of us share the author's equanimity, it's prudent to throw in our lot with trip organisers who've added leopard-spotting to their expertise. It's estimated that 100 to 300 snow leopards currently live in and around Ladakh. From end January to March, these cats move to lower, snow-free elevations, giving trackers a better chance to spot them. Typically scheduled for 12-14 days, snow leopard holidays are organised using the Ulley Valley as base, but of late, Uttarakhand has also begun organising tracking tours in high-altitude areas like Uttarkashi and Harsil.

The Museum of Faith

Home to the Gurdwara Sri Qatalgarh Sahib, Punjab's Chamkaur Sahib has been on the travel map of Sikh pilgrims for several decades. This is where Guru Gobind Singh's eldest sons—Saahibzaade Ajit and Jujhar Singh—died fighting the Mughals in 1704. To honour their sacrifice, the Punjab government recently inaugurated 'Daastan-e-Shahaadat', a theme park and museum, all rolled in one. Its 14 acres house 11 galleries that cover almost all the highlights of Sikh history.



THE HUMP MUSEUM

WINGS OF WAR

In January 2022, a new museum commemorating a long-forgotten chapter of WW2 will be opening its doors. The 'Hump Museum' in Pasighat, Arunachal Pradesh, will house artefacts recovered from some of the hundreds of transport aircraft lost in flying the perilous route from north-east India to the Chinese towns of Kunming and Chongqing, carrying supplies and troops to support the Kuomintang army's war effort against the Japanese Empire. The operation was a logistical triumph but it took its toll in aircraft—the remains of which lie scattered along the 'Aluminium trail', largely in the hills of Arunachal Pradesh. The new museum will honour the lives lost in these crashes, as well as the ongoing efforts to document these sites. It will also tell the surprising story of the Hump operation's legacy in jump-starting Indian civil aviation, particularly in the northeastern states.

